

25th Session of the Permanent Forum on
Indigenous Issues Statement on Behalf of the
Global Indigenous Women's Caucus Preparatory
Meeting Friday, April 17, 2026

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Preamble

On 17 April 2026, Indigenous Peoples from around the world gathered for the Global Indigenous Women's Caucus. This statement reflects the issues and concerns raised at that time. The following recommendations were informed by the statements made at the 2026 GIWC preparatory meeting.

Recommendations

**1. Empowering Indigenous agroecology and inherent relationships
with nature**

Article 25 of the UNDRIP states that Indigenous peoples have the right to maintain and strengthen their distinctive relationship with their lands, territories, waters and coastal seas and other resources and to uphold their responsibilities to future generations. However, so-called critical mineral mining practices worldwide are conducted in ways that violate our rights to free, prior, and informed consent. While portrayed as necessary for a just transition to green energy, mining poses a distinct threat to Indigenous physical, mental, and spiritual health. It pollutes our waters and lands, destroys biodiversity, exposes us to carcinogens and endocrine-disrupting chemicals, and contributes to spontaneous abortions as well as other maternal health issues. Indigenous relationships with

nature are based on the principles of reciprocity and stewardship, and the destruction from non-consensual mining causes a distinct form of trauma to our lands, minds, and bodies. We call on the World Health Organization to recognize the impact of “green” industry mining on Indigenous health and territories. As a key method to ensuring the survival of our traditional food systems and resisting assimilation into industrial agriculture, we call on the Food and Agriculture Organization to direct funding to initiatives by Indigenous organizations that support Indigenous agroecology.

2. Violations against women’s rights

Regarding General Recommendation No.39 (2022) on the rights of Indigenous women and girls, we recognize with great concern that Indigenous women continue to face disproportionate levels of discrimination, gender-based violence, and other violations of our rights, particularly in cases where Indigenous women are at risk due to displacement. One in three Indigenous women will experience rape in their lifetimes, and this increases for women who are forcibly removed from their lands or who experience detention. Too often, the rights of Indigenous women who are living in refugee camps, who are incarcerated, or who are experiencing threats from immigration enforcement fall through the cracks of our protections and their rights are violated by member states, who are not held accountable. We call on the ICJ and the Human Rights Council to convene a tribunal for women’s rights violations, including testimony and interventions from the Human Rights Council, to hold member states accountable for these violations.

3. Maternal health and Indigenous midwifery

Additionally, in accordance with UNDRIP articles 11 and 20, Indigenous reproductive rights and birthing practices, and the science that informs our traditions which have been proven effective since time immemorial, must be protected and respected. Indigenous women experience the highest levels of maternal mortality in the world, despite these deaths being entirely preventable. With reproductive health and maternal care under attack globally, we must draw attention to the fact that protections for Indigenous maternal care, including midwifery, are absent from General Recommendation No.39. These practices are crucial, not just to pass down traditional knowledge, but ensure the continued health and survival of our future generations. We call upon the Permanent Forum to add reproductive rights and maternal care to the future of work for Recommendation No.39, and call upon the World Health Organization (WHO) and the UNFPA to recognize Indigenous midwifery practices as a informed by Indigenous science and a legitimate and valuable source of maternal care and Indigenous survival, and urge member states to end its criminalization worldwide. We also ask that the WHO and UNFPA direct funding and attention to protecting women’s reproductive rights.

4. Funding to Indigenous women's organizations

Accordingly, we acknowledge the challenges faced by Indigenous women's grassroots organizations, whose work is protected by the right to participate in political and public life but who face intersecting barriers to effective, meaningful and real participation. Globally, Indigenous women and girls' organizations receive less than 1% of private sector philanthropic funding and face obstacles to their recognition as legal and capable entities at the national level, which challenges their access to funding and ability to work freely and independently. Article 23 of the UNDRIP states that "Indigenous peoples have the right to determine and develop priorities and strategies for exercising their right to development." As women leaders in our communities, we have solutions to our own problems and the capacity to manage these solutions. State intervention and attempts to manage our funding and organizations prevents us from completing the work to achieve our basic human rights and collective rights. Thus, we call on the World Bank to prioritize direct funding for Indigenous women's organizations, while emphasizing transparency in both the process and outcome of financing for these organizations.

5. Inequalities in Indigenous data collection and diversity

We are seeing an increasing diversity of our Indigenous relatives. Recommendation No.39 section 23(a) on Indigenous women's rights recommended that states should develop policies that include measures to address intersectional discrimination faced by Indigenous women and girls, including persons with disabilities, older women, persons of the LGBTQIA2S+ community, racialized and multi-ethnic women, and women challenged by mental health from all walks of life. In pursuit of SDG 10 on reduced inequalities, we request that states collect data disaggregated by age and disability status, in studies on gender-based discrimination and violence faced by Indigenous women and girls. Only with accurate data and reporting on our own diversity, including reporting that captures Indigenous gender identities that transcend the colonial binary, can we tackle the inequalities and rights abuses of Indigenous women, non-binary/Two Spirit relatives, and children worldwide.

6. Addressing Indigenous peoples in crisis and war zones

Finally, Article 7.2 of the UNDRIP clearly states: "Indigenous peoples have the collective right to live in freedom, peace and security as distinct peoples and shall not be subjected to any act of genocide or any other act of violence, including forcibly removing children of the group to another group." The Global Indigenous Women's Caucus strongly condemns the violations of these rights, which are occurring around the world in places like Gaza, Ukraine, Congo, Yemen, Sudan, Iran, Central and South America. We urge the Permanent Forum to enforce UNDRIP and the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR), including regarding the violence perpetuated against women

and girls in these contexts. Accordingly, we call upon the International Court of Justice (ICJ) to hold member states accountable for violations of UNDRIP and UDHR, including those guilty of perpetuating war crimes. We also call on the World Bank and all UN agencies, programs and entities to withhold any funding to corporations that would profit from oil, gas (which should include critical minerals) extraction in conflict zones or where genocide is being committed, in alignment with the World Bank's recommendations from the the One Planet Summit in 2017.

As Indigenous Women, we have the inherent responsibility to ensure a future, for our generations to come. Thank you.